one, however, could have been the monumental marking of the direction of prayer.

One final point awaits explication. Juzjani's mention of the Firuzkuh *jami'*s *pishtaq* (cf. above) hints at a monumental structure rather than an open space for prayer, probably in the same location to the east of the *minar*. This grand, most likely enclosed, building was evidently *in situ* by the mid-1190s, in time to display some of the Ajmer plunder. Such a mosque and its surely impressive *qibla* wall would have eventually blocked the view of the *mihrab* on the *minar*'s eastern face, seeming to replace it with the mosque's *qibla* wall. This blatant subordination of the *minar*'s *mihrab* could have resulted from the gradually fraying alliance between the Shansabani sultans and the Karramiyya, whose doctrinal sway over the region had led to the unusual choice of the entirety of Surat Maryam (Q. XIX) on the *minar*'s surface (cf. Chapter 4). But, by the 1170s and afterward, the Shansabanis' increasingly cosmopolitan ambitions required distance from the Karramiyya's admittedly reduced, localized appeal. It is worth considering, then, that a new *masjid-i jami'* was constructed sometime after the *minar*'s completion in 1174–1175 CE and before Juzjani's mention of the *jami' pishtaq* in the context of events occurring in 1194–1195 CE. This architectural gesture would have subtly but firmly sidelined the Karramiyya, while still maintaining the *minar*'s symbolism as the commemoration of the definitive Shansabani conquest of Ghazna (see esp. Chapter 4).

The Shansabanis' continued transhumance and their use of Jam-Firuzkuh as a *sard-sir* encampment helps to explain the absence of a permanent *qasr*, the role of palace amply fulfilled by "textile architecture" possibly in combination with small immoveable structures such as *kushk*s. Nevertheless, it might be expected that these ambitious elites made an early and enduring statement of their newfound dominance over Firuzkuh, an already existing settlement with established commercial networks. Prior to the famous *minar*, expending resources on the construction of a large place of prayer or *'idgah* would unequivocally declare their religio-political identity, concomitant with their commanding status, in the language of imperialism then current in the region: the strongly Persianate Islam of the Saljuqs and Ghaznavids. Prior to AH 570/1174–1175 CE and the erection of the famous *minar*, it is difficult to imagine how else the transhumant Shansabani elite would have made their presence felt at their *sard-sir* "capital" during their migratory absence for much of the year, if it were not for an enduring monument like a place of Islamic worship.

Ultimately, Jam-Firuzkuh makes a compelling case for an entirely different way of understanding the import of Persian textual sources in the study of something as seemingly indelible as architecture. Pre-modern Persian authors relied on a repertory of visual and poetic symbolism primarily derived from a sedentist royal court model, which did not concord